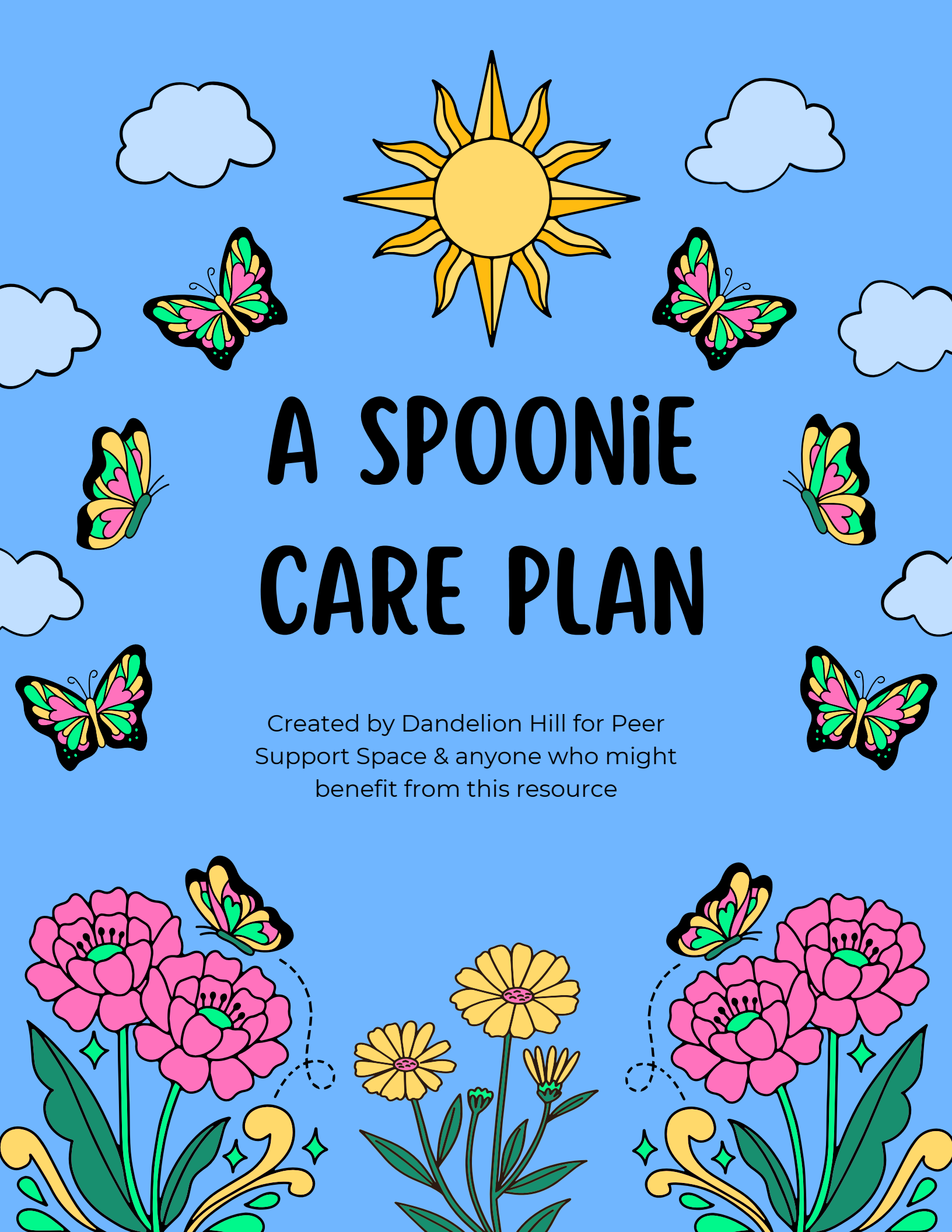


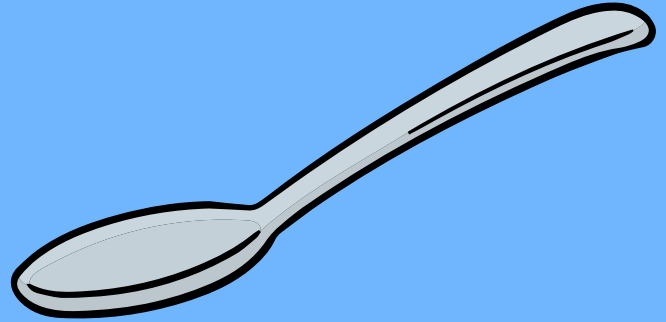


A SPOONIE CARE PLAN

Created by Dandelion Hill for Peer
Support Space & anyone who might
benefit from this resource

FIRST OF ALL, WHAT IS SPOON THEORY?

Spoon Theory, coined by Christine Miserandino, is an analogy that describes what it's like to live with a fatiguing chronic illness. It can help you explain to others your limits and boundaries around what you do each day.



Everything you do requires energy (spoons) from brushing your teeth to having a deep conversation. Spoon theory uses spoons to demonstrate how much energy such tasks require.

Getting dressed, taking medication, or watching television may use one spoon. Running errands, working, or visiting a relative may take four or more.

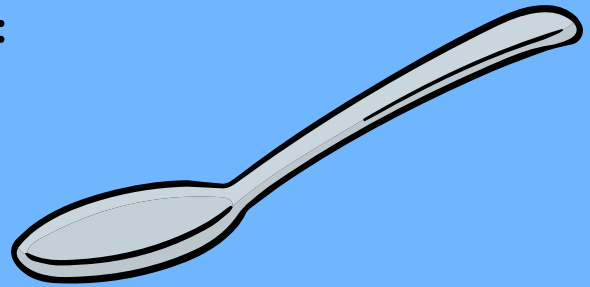
According to spoon theory, people without a disability or chronic health condition wake with enough spoons to tackle the expectations of their day. They can tend to their body, home, job or studies, and social plans and not worry that they'll run out of energy.

But a person with Disabled, Mad, Mentally Ill, Neurodivergent folks - we may have a limited number of spoons. Brain fog, confusion, pain, etc. can use up those spoons throughout the day.

If we try to use more spoons than we have, we can harm ourselves and find ourselves exhausted and unable to do anything more. Another consequence is if we overuse spoons in any given day we may feel exponentially worse tomorrow and even less spoons the next day.

ORIGINS OF SPOON THEORY

For the full story you can visit:
tinyurl.com/moreonspoons
which outlines Christine
Miserandino's full story.



The original spoon theory came from chronically ill blogger Christine Miserandino. Miserandino has lupus, an autoimmune disease. In 2003, she sat in a diner with a friend. Then the friend asked:
“What does it feel like to be sick?”

“How do I explain every detail of every day being affected and give the emotions a sick person goes through with clarity?”
Miserandino pondered on her blog.

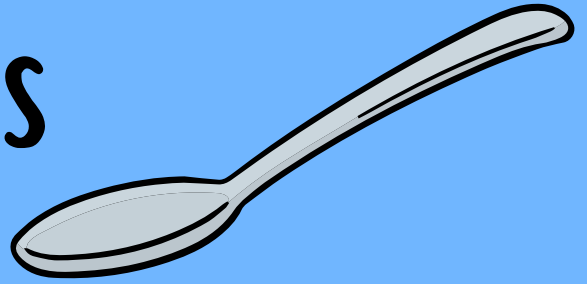
She grabbed spoons from tables, gave 12 to her friend, and asked her to describe an average day. As the friend listed activities, Miserandino took spoons from her. The spoons represented the amount of energy each activity required, she explained.

The more spoons used, the more the friend had to ration those she had left. By 7PM, her friend was out of spoons. And she hadn't gotten to do all she would have had she unlimited spoons.

Miserandino explained that she made such choices and sacrifices every single day because of her chronic illness. Her friend better understood how it felt to live with such loss.

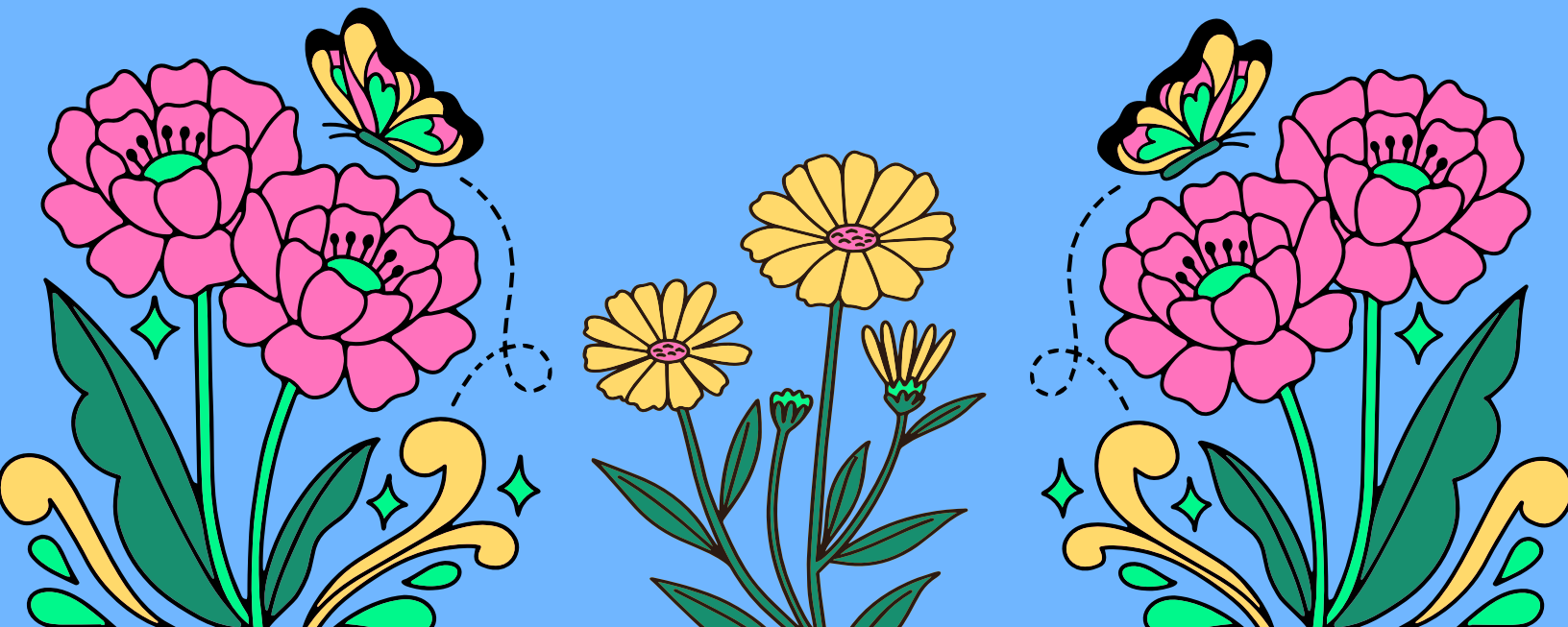
Now many Disabled, Mad, Mentally Ill, Neurodivergent comrades (**spoonies**) identify with the Spoon Theory and use it as a way to share about their energy and capacity with others.

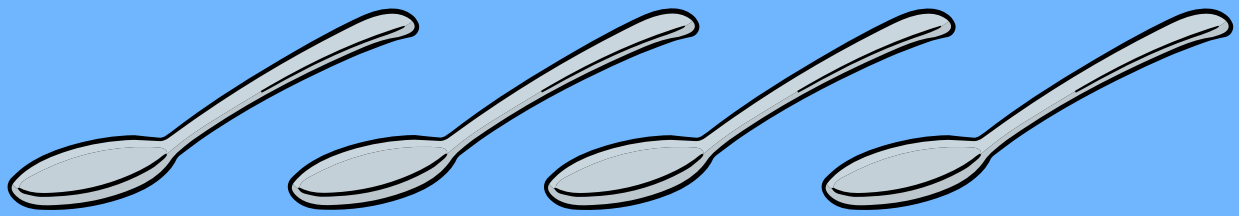
EVERYONE'S SPOONS AND SUPPORT NEEDS ARE DIFFERENT



Every person is unique and multifaceted. Our capacities, energy, and spoons may fluctuate based on so many factors (illness flare ups, emotional distress, conflicts in our relationships, grief - to name a just a few examples).

This care plan is meant to be a template that may be a useful tool to help you assess what your individual needs are. If this tool is not helpful for you - that is okay! Feel encouraged to modify, skip, or add things to your own plan - taking care of ourselves can look so many different ways - please only use this resource if it is helpful for you!





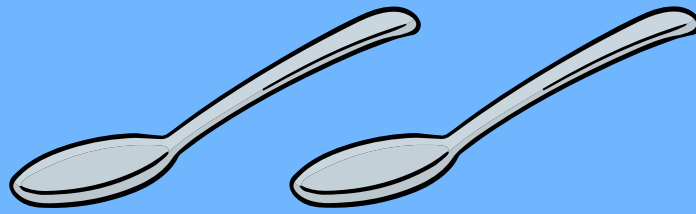
ON DAYS WHERE I HAVE A LOT OF SPOONS I CAN...

High spoon (energy and capacity) days may be rare. Considering what we want to do with these moments ahead of time might be helpful in maintaining our overall well-being.

Examples (take what resonates, ditch what doesn't)

On high spoon days I may...

have more capacity to hold space for those I care about, I might be able to tidy up my space, spend some extra time on my hygiene, cook myself a meal

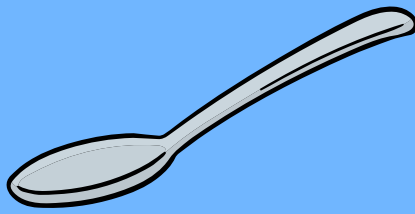


ON DAYS WHERE I HAVE A MODERATE AMOUNT OF SPOONS I CAN...

On moderate spoon (energy and capacity) days might be a sign that we need to be gentle with ourselves and take a little extra care to ensure we are okay.

Examples (take what resonates, ditch what doesn't)

On moderate spoon days I may...
need to be more careful with energy,
take a nap, call a friend for support,, order food or make an easy
microwave meal



ON DAYS WHERE I HAVE LOW SPOONS I CAN...

On low spoon days I may have to be extra gentle with myself and honor my capacity.

Examples (take what resonates, ditch what doesn't)

On low spoon days I may...

need to be more extra with energy,

tag in a support person to help me get my needs met, spend extra time resting, play some cozy games, snack on easy to access treats that don't require cooking

UH OH, I'M OUT OF SPOONS...

On no spoon days - we may have increased support and care needs. It can help to plan ahead when we can what we need on these days and who we can lean on for support.

...I NEED HELP WITH...

Examples (take what resonates, ditch what doesn't)

On no spoon days I may need...

to have someone cook or order my meals for me, have someone help ensure my survival needs are met, need someone to hold space for me or sit with me and watch something calming while I rest

WHO ARE MY SUPPORTERS?

Finding friends and supporters to give us care can be hard, it's okay and really common not to have folks to lean on when you need help. If you don't have folks to identify yet, it's okay! Skip to the next slide which offers some resources that may help in building a network of care for yourself.

Tip -practice consent and check in!

Though we may need support those we are close to might not have capacity to provide what we need. Talking to our network of friends and supporters about what can and can't do is a really important step in getting our needs met. It also might be helpful to have these conversations when spoons are a little higher.

RESOURCES FOR CONNECTING WITH COMMUNITY AND SUPPORT

Every person is unique and what is helpful will vary person to person. Please take what resonates and ditch what doesn't.

Peer Support Space - www.PeerSupportSpace.org, Mary@PeerSupportSpace.org for more info. Lived experience led resource that has virtual (and Orlando based in person) groups and individual support offerings.

Kiva Center - KivaCenters.org, Info@KivaCenters.Org for more info. Has virtual peer led resources.

Wildflower Alliance - WildFlowerAlliance.org - peer led phone support, virtual spaces, and zoom groups.

Tender Fruits Collective - TenderFruitsCollective.com - Queer, Trans, Mad Sick, and Disabled, Survivor led peer support spaces.

Yarrow Collective - YarrowCollective.org - lived experience peer led collective that has virtual group support resources.

LUNA Community Care - LunaCommunityCare.org - online and in-person peer-led cooperative by and for Neurodivergent adults.

I'M IN CRISIS, THESE ARE MY NEEDS...

Crisis is an umbrella term that can mean a lot of things, but in this instance we are referring to inability to self-tend and heightened need for others to tag in. When in crisis we may need to go to the hospital, conversely we may want to avoid that altogether and take steps to stay home and have care done there. While in crisis it can be extra hard to advocate for ourselves so it can be helpful to consider this plan in advance when possible.

Tip - share this with your network of supporters where comfy; it can be helpful to do this when spoons are higher and before a crisis happens.

Examples: please do not call law enforcement to intervene when I am struggling, if I need to go to the hospital I'd like to avoid _____ and go _____ instead, you may check in with _____, please do not contact _____.